



Some Favourites of Chitra

Favourite food - Curd Rice

Favourite drink - Chai

Favourite actor - Rajini

Favourite actress - Suhasini

Favourite music - Devotional music

Favourite movie - Meera (1945, Starring MS Subbulakshmi) and Munnabhai MBBS (Tamil)

Texts she reads - Sanskrit verses

End-to-end governance was a quality deeply ingrained in Chitra. “As we neared the tape-out deadline, the amount of time at work increased,” she says. Every tape-out was a celebration with the whole team and usually happened late at night or in the wee hours of the morning.

While building a strong silicon engineering team, Chitra forged deep bonds with her team members and even their family members. Recalling an incident from her days at Open-Silicon, Chitra says, “A colleague Kailas had gone to the ATM to withdraw some cash and for some reason the card didn’t work. When he returned empty-handed, his daughter Kasturi asked him, ‘*Kya hua? Chitra aunty ne paise nahi diye kya?*’ She thought that I was sitting and handing out money. We all had a hearty laugh the next day.”

Amid the laughs and the late nights, Chitra had a constant companion—*chai*. In the initial weeks of setting up Concept2Silicon—her third chip startup venture as a founding member, and this time co-founder—funds ran low, and aspirations soared high. The year was 2009 and the global economic crisis had rattled the investors’ spirits. “Everyone was ready to invest to accelerate but nobody wanted to provide seed money. We had a team ready to work, but no salaries to pay,” she says.

When spirits started running

low, Chitra infused the team with her zest and vigour. “I told them, for the next month we will work hard enough to fund our *chai*! The team responded with action and the next month it was working for our *chai* and lunch. We bagged our first customer in just three months of founding the company,” she recounts.

A believer of simple living and high thinking, Chitra stuck to her humble roots, taking pride in her hard work and achievements. For a long while, she navigated through Bengaluru traffic, chasing design wins in her Maruti Alto. “The conversation regarding the acquisition of Concept2Silicon by HCL happened in my Maruti Alto with the HCL leader and my co-founders, Dr Satya Gupta, Ravi Srinivasan. I had that car for a very long time and refused to part with it. It was only after the acquisition that I decided to buy a bigger car and rewarded myself with a Honda City,” she shares.

Exemplifying the story of the squirrel helping Lord Rama, the hero of the epic *Ramayana*, and incarnation of *Hindu* deity Vishnu, Chitra believes that a leader should value and acknowledge the contribution of every team member. “Inclusivity and recognition are two wheels of the same bicycle that ensure on-time and first-time successful silicon tape-outs,” she says.

Recounting the first time she felt she was a part of building something big, Chitra proudly recalls her time at the Madras VLSI Design Centre of ITI. “I was a part of the team that designed a chip for ISRO’s Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV)!”

As a woman in electronics, Chitra believes that diversity isn’t just confined to gender alone. “It is about taking everyone along with you and respecting everyone’s views and contribution to get the best results for the team,” she says.

Slowing down? Nah!

Chitra calls herself a go-getter, and true to her nature, to date, she has never stopped grabbing the horse by the reins and steering it towards her goals. After shuttling for three decades, four successful semiconductor startups, and a strong connection with the venture capital community and academia, Chitra is now actively improving the VLSI and chip design education by bringing foundational changes and aiding semiconductor startups in building connections with VCs and real customers.

A firm believer and enforcer of purpose-driven collaboration, as the Secretary of the VLSI Society of India, Chitra is now actively working to bring together the courses necessary to strengthen VLSI hardware design education on one common platform to enable knowledge sharing. “This way every institution can learn and evolve its curriculum to churn out the best hardware designers in the country,” she declares.

With no regrets, was there anything that she would do differently? “I really wish I was born 20 years later because this is the golden era for India and semiconductors. We have waited for these kinds of growth opportunities for a long time. The playing field has levelled and there are equal opportunities for women. You just need to grab the opportunities and run with them,” she opines.

“The policies, incentives and environment are extremely conducive to build electronics and semiconductor products for India. With the right focus on education and product startups, India is poised to become a strong hardware product nation in the coming decades,” she concludes.

Chitra Hariharan is currently working for Renesas India, heading the Academia Relations, Government Affairs, and Startup Collaborations. **EFY**